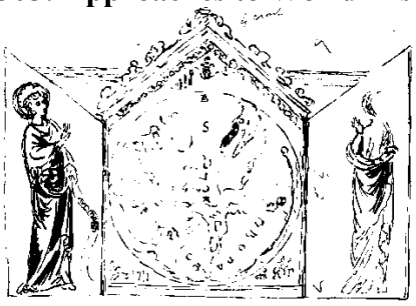
Department of History
National University of Singapore

HY5305: Approaches to World History



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Office hours: By appt

AY 2026-27
Semester 1
Class hours: Thurs 6-9 pm
Classroom: LT14

Approaches to World History:
Global History in Curatorial Contexts

Course description

This graduate-level course introduces key global history frameworks, in particular as it relates to the interpretation and presentation of world history in museum contexts. It focuses on how global histories are constructed, organised, and translated into narratives and exhibitions. Students will examine approaches such as comparative, connected and transnational history, with attention to space, time, scale, narrative and the challenges of representing diverse pasts within shared spaces.

This iteration of Approaches to World History emphasises curatorial practice as a form of historical interpretation. Museums are treated as sites where global frameworks are made visible through selection, arrangement and storytelling. The course explores how curators use objects, themes and spatial design to articulate connections across regions and periods, and how different frameworks shape what is included, excluded or emphasised.

Learning Outcomes

1. Understand key frameworks used to interpret and organise world history, particularly in relation to scale, connection and comparison.
2. Apply these frameworks to the curation of global histories in museum contexts, including the selection and interpretation of objects and narratives.
3. Critically assess how different curatorial approaches shape the representation and communication of global pasts to public audiences.

Assessment

40%	Poster & project explanation (2300-2500 words), due by **Sun, 15 Nov**
20%	Poster/ project presentation (Weeks 8-10)
20%	Abstract submission (300-500 words), due by **Wed, 16 Sept**
20%	Class participation/ activities

Class Participation (20%)

This is a graduate seminar in which you will learn from each other and whose success depends on your contributions to class discussions. You are expected to prepare thoroughly for class as best you can:

1. **Readings**

Students are expected to complete their required readings and to engage the instructor and each other in discussions in class. All required readings are available on Canvas (Files > Readings). You may be called upon to summarise required readings. You are also encouraged to drop discussion questions in Canvas (Discussion board) after you have completed your required readings before the class – we may use some of these questions in our class discussion.

Time-permitting, you are encouraged to read titles in the further reading section and should be using some of this literature for your research project. The key to managing your time effectively is to learn how to read / watch for the main ideas, so that you do not get mired in the details (i.e. skim read). It also helps to annotate the readings and/ or write down your major takeaways from them. What questions do they raise? What is interesting / provocative about them? How do they relate to my existing knowledge of the subject and to previous readings? If you think these make for interesting class discussions with your tutor and peers, please put them in the Canvas question bank (Discussion board). No question is too trivial!

2. **In-class discussions**

Class will typically be structured around small-group discussions that lead into more general discussion. Please participate regularly and don't worry about expressing half-formed ideas. Think of class as a way for you to refine your own ideas and hone your speaking skills. The material we discuss could be controversial/ contested and may challenge your preconceived notions of history. But that's the whole point of the course. Please be thoughtful, respectful, self-reflexive and constructive in your contributions, and don't be afraid to disagree with others (including the instructor). What is said in the classroom stays in the classroom.

*Please note that all class activities will count towards your participation grade (20%). Other assessment elements are explained in a separate document.

Timetable

Instructional Weeks	***Thursday*** ***Seminar*** 18:00-21:00
[1] **Aug 13**	*Introduction to course and the practice of global history*
[2] **Aug 20**	*The practice of global history (continued); global history vs microhistory*
[3] **Aug 27**	*Space and place in global history/ globalisation studies*
[4] **Sept 3**	*Time in global history/ globalisation studies*
[5] **Sept 10**	*Collecting global cultures: the birth of the universal museum*
[6] **Sept 17**	*Collecting global cultures II: object histories and global narratives*
Recess Week	***Sept 19-27***
[7] **1 Oct**	*Self-guided (non-NUS) museum visit (with e-worksheet)*
[8] **Oct 8**	*Poster Presentation*
[9] **Oct 15**	*Poster Presentation II*
[10] **Oct 22**	*Poster Presentation III*
[11] **Oct 29**	*NUS Museum visit (Global histories of Hindu-Buddhist art)*
[12] **Nov 5**	*Wrapping up; consultations*
Poster & project explanation (2300-2500 words), due by **Sun, 15 Nov**	

WEEK	TOPICS / READINGS

1 **13 August**

Introduction; course briefing

2 **20 August**

Topic: The practice of global history (continued); global history vs microhistory

Required reading for discussion

O'Brien, P. (2006). Historiographical traditions and modern imperatives for the restoration of global history. *Journal of Global History*, 1(1), 3-39.

Ghobrial, J. P. A. (2019). Introduction: Seeing the World like a Microhistorian. *Past & Present*, 242 (Supplement 14), 1-22.

3 **27 August**

Topic: Space and place in global history/ globalisation studies

Required reading for discussion

Massey, D. (2002). Globalisation: What does it mean for geography? *Geography* 87(4), 293-296.

Kalandides, A. (2020). Doreen Massey's 'a global sense of place' revisited. In Edensor, T., Kalandides, A. & Kothari, U. (eds.) *The Routledge Handbook of Place*. London: Routledge, 32-41.

4 **3 September**

Topic: Time in global history/ globalisation studies

Required reading for discussion

Barad, K. (2017). Troubling time/s and ecologies of nothingness: Re-turning, re-membering, and facing the incalculable. *New Formations*, 92, 56-86.

5 **10 September**

Topic: Collecting global cultures: the birth of the universal museum

Required reading for discussion

Buschmann, R. F. (2018). Oceanic collections in German museums: Collections, contexts, and exhibits. In. Carreau, L. et al (eds.) *Pacific Presences: Oceanic Art and European Museums*, Sidestone Press, 197-227.

El-Tayeb, F. (2020). The universal museum: How the New Germany built its future on colonial amnesia. *Nka: Journal of Contemporary African Art*, 46, 72-82.

6 **17 September**

Topic: Collecting global cultures II: object histories and global narratives

Required reading for discussion
Riello, G. (2022). The "material turn" in world and global history. *Journal of World History*, 33(2), 193-232.

Abstract submission (300 words) due Wed, 16 Sept

RECESS WEEK – WORK ON YOUR PROJECT

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7 **1 October**

Self-guided museum visit & worksheet (no in-class seminar this week)

8 **8 October**

Poster/Project Presentations I

9 **15 October**

Poster/Project Presentations II

10 **22 October**

Poster/Project Presentations III

11 **29 October**

NUS Museum Visit (Global Histories of Hindu-Buddhist art)

12 **5 November**

Wrap-up & consultations

POSTER & PROJECT EXPLANATION DUE BY SUNDAY, 15 NOVEMBER

Further reading

Global histories of objects

Blurton, R. (2022). *India: A History in Objects*. British Museum Press.

Cooke, E. S. (2022). *Global Objects: Toward a Connected Art History*. Princeton University Press.

Flood, F. B. (2009). *Objects of translation: Material culture and medieval" Hindu-Muslim" encounter*. Princeton University Press.

Flood, F. B., & Fricke, B. (2024). *Tales Things Tell: Material Histories of Early Globalisms*. Princeton University Press.

Harrison-Hall, J. (2017). *China: A History in Objects*. British Museum Press.

Hicks, D. & Whyte, W. (2020). *A Cultural History of Objects* (6 vols.). Bloomsbury.

Keene, B. C. (Ed.). (2019). *Toward a Global Middle Ages: Encountering the World through Illuminated Manuscripts*. Getty Publications.

Kieschnick, J. (2003). *The Impact of Buddhism on Chinese Material Culture*. Princeton University Press.

Lambourn, E.A. (2018). *Abraham's Luggage: A Social Life of Things in the Medieval Indian Ocean World*. Cambridge University Press.

MacGregor, N. (2011). *A History of the World in 100 Objects*. Penguin UK.

Miller, P. N. (2017). *History and its objects: antiquarianism and material culture since 1500*. Cornell University Press.

Milwright, M. (Ed.). (2025). *Encounters: Medieval Islamic History in 50 Objects*. Taylor & Francis.

O'Toole, F. (2013). *A History of Ireland in 100 Objects*. Royal Irish Academy.

Riello, G. (2017). Things that shape history: material culture and historical narratives. In Harvey, K. (ed.) *History and Material Culture.* Routledge, 27-50.

Time and global history

Barad, K. (2001). Re(con)figuring space, time, and matter. *Feminist Locations: Global and Local, Theory and Practice*, *75109*.

Borges, J.L. (1962). A New Refutation of Time In idem *Labyrinths*. New Directions

Hristova, M., Ferrándiz, F., & Vollmeyer, J. (2020). Memory worlds: Reframing time and the past–An introduction. *Memory Studies*, 13(5), 777-791.

https://www.themarginalian.org/2016/09/19/a-new-refutation-of-time-borges/

https://www.themarginalian.org/2016/01/18/intuition-of-the-instant-gaston-bachelard/

Space and global history

Andaya, B. W. (2017). Seas, oceans and cosmologies in Southeast Asia. *Journal of Southeast Asian Studies*, 48(3), 349-371. [NUS Library Online]

Cresswell, T. (2013). *Place: A Short Introduction*. John Wiley & Sons.

Edensor, T., Kalandides, A., & Kothari, U. (eds.). (2020). *The Routledge Handbook of Place*. Routledge.

Massey, D. (1991). A global sense of place. *Marxism Today*, June, 24–29.

Massey, D. (1995). The conceptualisation of place. In D. Massey & P. Jess (Eds.), *A place in the world: Places, cultures and globalisation*. Buckingham: Open University Press, 46-79

Massey, D. (2003). Globalisation: What does it mean for geography?. *Development Education Journal*, 9(2), 3-5.

Prange, S. R. (2008). Scholars and the sea: A historiography of the Indian Ocean. *History Compass*, *6*(5), 1382-1393. [NUS Library Online]

Roudometof, V. (2019). Recovering the local: From glocalization to localization. *Current Sociology*, 67(6), 801-817.

Thomas, J. A. (2017). Why Do Only Some Places Have History? Japan, the West, and the Geography of the Past. *Journal of World History*, 28(2), 187-218.

Wenzlhuemer, R. (2010). Globalization, communication and the concept of space in global history. *Historical Social Research/Historische Sozialforschung*, 19-47.

Bio-histories as global history

Boivin, N. (2017). Proto-globalisation and biotic exchange in the Old World. In. idem (ed.) *Human Dispersal and Species Movement from Prehistory to the Present*, University of Cambridge Press, 349-408

Boivin, N., Crowther, A., Prendergast, M., & Fuller, D. Q. (2014). Indian Ocean food globalisation and Africa. *African Archaeological Review*, 31(4), 547-581.

Boivin, N., Fuller, D. Q., & Crowther, A. (2012). Old World globalization and the Columbian exchange: comparison and contrast. *World Archaeology*, 44(3), 452-469.

Bray, F., Hahn, B., Lourdusamy, J. B., & Saraiva, T. (2023). *Moving Crops and the Scales of History*. Yale University Press.

Brunning, S. et al (2024). *Silk Roads*. British Museum Press.

Crosby, A. W. (1972). *The Columbian Exchange: Biological and Cultural Consequences of 1492*. Greenwood Press.

Eisenberg, M., & Mordechai, L. (2020). The Justinianic plague and global pandemics: The making of the plague concept. *The American Historical Review*, 125(5), 1632-1667.

Fuller, D. Q., Boivin, N., Hoogervorst, T., & Allaby, R. (2011). Across the Indian Ocean: the prehistoric movement of plants and animals. *Antiquity*, 85(328), 544-558.

Harrison, M. (2015). A Global Perspective: Reframing the History of Health, Medicine, and Disease. *Bulletin of the History of Medicine*, 89(4), 639-689.

Mann, C. C. (2019). Columbian exchange. In *The Routledge Handbook to the History and Society of the Americas* (pp. 67-74). Routledge.

McNeill, W. H. (1999). How the potato changed the world's history. *Social research*, 67-83.

Spengler, R. N. (2020). *Fruit from the sands: the Silk Road origins of the foods we eat*. University of California Press.

Museum origins and collecting cultures

Abt, J. (2006). The Origins of the Public Museum. In. Macdonald, S. (ed.) *A Companion to Museum Studies*. Malden: Blackwell, 115-134

Davies, S. (2021). Catalogical encounters: Worldmaking in early modern cabinets of curiosities. In Findlen, P. (ed.) *Early Modern Things*. Routledge, 227-254.

Delbourgo, J. (2019). *Collecting the World: Hans Sloane and the Origins of the British Museum*. Harvard University Press.

Garrison, M.B. (2012). Antiquarianism, Copying, Collecting. In Potts, D.T. (ed.) *A Companion to the Archaeology of the Ancient Near East*. Blackwell, 27-47.

Impey, O. and MacGregor, A. (1985). *The Origins of Museums: The Cabinet of Curiosities in Sixteenth- and Seventeenth-Century Europe.* Clarendon Press.

Macdonald, S. (2006). Collecting Practices. In. Macdonald, S. (ed.) *A Companion to Museum Studies*. Malden: Blackwell, 81-97

MacGregor, A. (2007). *Curiosity and Enlightenment: Collectors and Collections from the Sixteenth to the Nineteenth Century*. Yale University Press.

MacGregor, A. (ed.) (1983). *Tradescant's Rarities: Essays on the Foundation of the Ashmolean Museum*. Clarendon Press.

Mauriès, P. (2011). *Cabinets of Curiosities*. Thames & Hudson.

Meadow, M.A. and Robertson, B. (2013). *The First Treatise on Museums: Samuel Quiccheberg's 'Inscriptiones' 1565.* Getty Research Institute.

Schnapp, A. (ed.). (2014). *World Antiquarianism: Comparative Perspectives*. Getty Publications.

Schwarzer, M. (2006). *Riches, rivals & radicals: 100 years of museums in America*. American Association of Museums.

Simmons, J. E. (2016). *Museums: A History*. Rowman & Littlefield

Colonial power, collecting practices and imperial museums

Finnegan, D. A., & Wright, J. J. (2016). *Spaces of global knowledge: exhibition, encounter and exchange in an age of empire*. Routledge.

Hinsley Jr, C. M. (1981). Savages and scientists: The Smithsonian Institution and the development of American anthropology, 1846-1910. Smithsonian Institutution.

Longair, S. and Jeppesen, C. (2020). Domestic museums of decolonisation?: Objects, colonial officials, and the afterlives of empire in Britain. In Sèbe, B. and Stanard, M.G. (eds.) *Decolonising Europe? Popular Responses to the End of Empire*. Routledge, 220-237.

Longair, S., & McAleer, J. (eds.) (2012). *Curating Empire: Museums and the British Imperial Experience*. Manchester University Press.

MacKenzie, J. M. (2009). *Museums and Empire: Natural History, Human Cultures and Colonial Identities*. Manchester University Press.

Reid, D. M. (2002). *Whose Pharaohs? archaeology, museums, and Egyptian national identity from Napoleon to World War I*. University of California Press.

Wintle, C. (2013). *Colonial collecting and display: encounters with material culture from the Andaman and Nicobar islands*. Berghahn Books.

Miscellaneous

Barrows, L. C. (2021). Ancient Worlds: A Global History of Antiquity. *Comparative Civilizations Review*, 85, 203-206.

Cobb, M. A. (2018). Introduction: the Indian Ocean in Antiquity and global history. In idem (ed.) *The Indian Ocean Trade in Antiquity*. Routledge, 1-14.

Curry-Machado, J. (2013). Global Histories, Imperial Commodities, Local Interactions: An Introduction. In idem (ed.), *Global Histories, Imperial Commodities, Local Interactions*. London: Palgrave Macmillan UK, 1-14.

Henderson, J., Morgan, S. L., & Salonia, M. (Eds.). (2024). *Reimagining the Silk Roads: Interactions and Perceptions across Eurasia*. Taylor & Francis.

Heng, G. (2021). *The Global Middle Ages: An Introduction*. Cambridge University Press.

Hoppit, J. (2018). Sir Joseph Banks's provincial turn. *The Historical Journal*, 61(2), 403-429.

Klimek, K., Troyer, P., Davis-Secord, S., & Keene, B. C. (2021). *Global Medieval Contexts 500–1500: Connections and Comparisons*. Routledge.

Millward, J. A. (2013). *The Silk Road: A very short introduction*. Oxford University Press.

Northrop, D. (ed.). (2012). *A Companion to World History*. John Wiley & Sons.

Olstein, D. (2015). Thinking History Globally: Contextualizing on a Bigger Scale. In *Thinking History Globally*. Palgrave Macmillan UK, 140-156.

Respess, A. (2024). *Global Ships: Seafaring, Shipwrecks, and Boatbuilding in the Global Middle Ages*. Cambridge University Press.

Sivasundaram, S. (2010). Sciences and the global: on methods, questions, and theory. *Isis*, 101(1), 146-158.

Stanziani, A. (2018). Why We Need Global History. In *Eurocentrism and the Politics of Global History*. Springer International Publishing, 1-19.

van der Vleuten, E., de Hoop, E., van der Straeten, J., Akallah, J. A., Chatterjee, A., Heymann, M., & Kumar, P. (2025). Roundtable: Global Histories of Technology in Worlds of Environmental Change. *Technology and Culture*, 66(1), 11-37.

Vanhaute, E. (2009). Who is afraid of global history? Ambitions, pitfalls and limits of learning global history. *Österreichische Zeitschrift für Geschichtswissenschaften*, 20(2), 22-39.

Vanhaute, E. (2013). *World history: an introduction*. Routledge.

Vries, P. (2009). Global history. *Österreichische Zeitschrift für Geschichtswissenschaften*, 20(2), 5-21.

Weller, R. C. (2017). ‘Grand Narrative’ and ‘New’World Histories: Their Historical Challenges and Contributions in Western Scholarship. In Weller, C. (ed.) *21st-Century Narratives of World History: Global and Multidisciplinary Perspectives*. Springer International Publishing, 3-33

Wenzlhuemer, R. (2016). The ship, the media, and the world: conceptualizing connections in global history. *Journal of Global History*, 11(2), 163-186.

Wenzlhuemer, R. (2019). *Doing Global History: An Introduction in 6 Concepts*. Bloomsbury Publishing. [has discussions on space and time in global history]

Whitfield, S.(2019). *Silk Roads: Peoples, Cultures, Landscapes*. Thames & Hudson.